

saying, "...if the DS succeeds, we will rise to heaven, but if it fails we will sink to hell."

In many ways, the DS was Nintendo shaking the boat just to see what sticks and what sinks. As far as the company was concerned, these were the worst of times: the Japanese gaming market was shrinking, or stagnant at best. The gaming population was seeing little growth; gamers were dropping out to real-life and questing to more the mundane things: job, wife, loans, kids. Female gamers were as rare as ever, as were gamers above the age of 40. In this environment, competing against Microsoft and Sony was a losing gambit. Nintendo thus decided that their best bet would be to expand the market and dip its toes in the virgin waters thus created. Lapsed gamers, women, and the aging populace would thus be targeted, along with the usual army of Nintendo fans.

Thus was the DS born: with a touch screen to simplify controls. At one point, Nintendo entertained the thought of doing away with all buttons save for the touch screen. Similarly the DS' microphone and wireless networking features were meant to increase interaction with a game and simplify the multiplayer experience. But designing the hardware was half the battle. With games such as *Nintendogs* (wooing the female population with cute puppies), *Brain Training* (luring an ageing Japan to keep their brains sharpened), *Brain Age*, and *New Super Mario Bros.* (capturing the thus newly-created market and the lapsed gamer with the simple and familiar world of Mario), Nintendo successfully expanded the gaming market.

The strategy was a huge success. The DS/DS Lite is the fastest selling console in Japan and has sold over 25 million units worldwide in less than two years. The company now hopes to emulate its success in the home console market with the Nintendo Wii.

Worst. Name. Ever?

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nomenclature followed its new philosophy of all-access gaming. Wii (we) was for everyone—you, your sister, your mom, your granddad, and so on. On a quiet day, you can still hear the giggles, but Nintendo might yet have the last laugh.

The Nintendo Wii is a system like no other. Iwata had a vision for what Nintendo terms its "new-generation" console: it should be small, quiet, cool (thermally), approachable (don't scare the moms away), and sexy. It should be easy to play on the Wii (snigger), the controller must not be a mess of buttons, the Wii should be always on and rearing to go (groan).

With these broad directions, Nintendo's engineers designed what is perhaps the most unique gaming device to grace Mario's Green Earth.

Waggle time

The most striking feature of the Wii is doubtless its controller. Dubbed the Wii Remote and rechristened "Wiimote" by the Internet, the controller resembles a simplified TV remote—something everyone is familiar and comfortable with. The Wiimote can be waved as a sword, or swung as a bat or golf club; it can be cast as a fishing reel, or used as a steering wheel.

The Wiimote gets its mojo from motion tracking: it can detect its own position and orientation via a conjunction of accelerometers and an infrared sensor. The accelerometers determine roll, pitch, yaw, and directional movements. These are then communicated to the console via Bluetooth. The Wiimote can also track its own position relative to the console: this is done via a thin, small sensor bar that can either sit above or below a TV set—the bar houses infrared lights that are tracked by a camera embedded in the Wiimote, much like an actual TV remote's IR window. The Wiimote is thus able to act as a pointer on the TV screen, analogous to how a PC mouse works: small movements on the mouse pad are converted to mouse movements onscreen.

A game made for the Wii may or may not make use of this pointer functionality—action FPS *Red Steel* does, while racing game *Excite Truck* doesn't.

When the Wiimote was designed, Shigeru



The Games

Red Steel

The game employs the Wiimote as a gun and the Nunchuk to lob grenades and take cover. Shaking the Nunchuk reloads a weapon, pushing the Wiimote forward can topple furniture which can be used as cover. The Wiimote also acts as a sword, controlling a Katana, while the Nunchuk is used to block the enemy's sword attacks. The game offers split-screen multiplayer in which objectives are spoken to each player through the Wiimote's speakers.

Wii Sports

A collection of four sports titles: Golf, Baseball, Bowling, and Boxing, *Wii Sports* is bundled free with the console in all regions except Japan. Under golf and baseball, the Wiimote acts as the club and as you swing the controller, the on-screen character mimics your motion. For bowling, you need to make an underhand motion, similar to real bowling. Boxing pitches the Wiimote as your right glove and the Nunchuk as your left

glove—you can thus punch as in real-life and swerve left to right in order to dodge an opponent's hits. *Wii Sports* uses Mii avatars to represent you.

Excite Truck

A fast-paced racing game, it uses the Wiimote in the horizontal position as a steering wheel. While you can swerve your truck left to right by moving the controller, you can boost yourself via the D-pad. The game will also play your MP3s via the Wii's SD card slot.

The Legend of Zelda: Twilight Princess

Widely heralded as the best Zelda game yet, this 70+ hour action-adventure-role-playing-game is perhaps the most ambitious undertaking by Nintendo. The game uses the Wiimote to make sword slashes, or throw a boomerang, or aim arrows, and more. The Nunchuk is used to execute spin attacks and for movement.